RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

He Exists Before All: The First Principle

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 8

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: Principle 1 in depth; the start of Principle 2

Shiur: Part 8 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 25 November 2025

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Recap

The Mishnah: **כל ישראל יש להם חלק לעולם הבא**. Who has a portion? **Those who believe the 13 Principles.** Last week:

- The Rambam's **emphasis on belief** (converts, Yevamot)

- Other counts: **three, one, none** (the Radbaz)

- **Why principles matter**: **ignorance is no excuse**

Tonight: **Principle 1 dissected**, and the Rishonim's arguments.

היסוד הראשון: להאמין מציאות הבורא יתברך... שיש שם נמצא שלם בכל דרכי המציאות, והוא עילת מציאות הנמצאים כלם... ואם נעלה על לבנו העדר כל הנמצאים זולתו, לא תתבטל מציאות השם יתברך ולא תגרע... וזה היסוד הראשון, מורה עליו הדבור אנכי ה׳ אלהיך.

Part 1: The Five Elements

1. There is a Creator

"**Straightforward.** Whether creation was **from nothing** or from **pre-existent matter** as old as God (as **Ibn Ezra** and others held) is **Principle 4**."

2. He is perfect

Harold Kushner's *When Bad Things Happen to Good People*: the leading Conservative rabbi argued God **wants** to stop evil but **can't**. "**According to the Rambam, and everyone, that's a misunderstanding of God. His essence is perfection**, which means **omnipotence**."

Can God do the impossible? (Discussed with Rav Saadia on Monday nights.) *Can He make a rock He can't lift?*

No, and that's no imperfection. "**It's semantics**: we hear *can't* and think *weakness*. **Hashem can't catch flu**: He's not physical. Rav Saadia's example: **He can't make a square a triangle.**"

The Rambam (Moreh): we don't call a man **weak** because he can't lift **100,000 weights**. Nor is God incapable because He can't **make Himself corporeal**, **create His equal**, or make **a square**

whose diagonal equals its side.

The dissent: Rebbe Nachman of Breslov: *the philosophers say God can't make a triangle a square; I say He can, for His ways are hidden.* "**Rebbe Nachman hated philosophers and doctors: both of which the Rambam was.** A minority view, **not logically sound**."

3. He depends on nothing

A consequence of perfection. אדון עולם אשר מלך בטרם כל יציר נברא: He reigned **before** anything was formed.

"Hashem doesn't need our prayers." "Contrary to **Christian theology**. We sometimes talk as if Hashem is **waiting** for our tefillot. **Prayer is transformative, for our own sake**: a meditation for our intellectual and moral development." "If I didn't know Hebrew and read **the English of the siddur**, through a Western, Christian lens, I wouldn't want to pray: *holy, holy, holy, we worship You...* **as if God needs us.** It's quite **babyish**."

4. Everything depends on Him, continuously

Not a God who created and left (deism). "**Even if you believe in a perfect, independent Creator who then left the world, that isn't Hashem.**" **המחדש בטובו בכל יום תמיד מעשה בראשית.**

The imagined universe. "Create a beautiful universe **in your mind**. It exists only **while you're thinking of it**. Someone tells you some news, your attention slips, **it's gone**." So Hashem **actively sustains** every element, **every moment**. "No carpenter who makes something and walks away."

5. His existence is necessary

From the **Mishneh Torah**: **ה' אלהים אמת**: "**Two plus two is four**, not merely logically: it **must** be. **That's *emet*.**"

Yigdal and **Ani Ma'amin** lack **perfection**; Ani Ma'amin has **continuous involvement** (**עשה ועושה ויעשה**).

Part 2: Arguments for a Creator

"It's not my expertise; I'll share what's in the Rishonim."

Three caveats:

1. **No proof will be 100%.** If it were, **there'd be no free will.** We seek **beyond reasonable doubt**.
2. **Unconscious bias.Aldous Huxley**, the prominent British writer, admitted that he and his friends **wanted** the world to have no meaning: meaninglessness **freed them from morality**, above all **sexual** morality.
   The Gemara (Sanhedrin 63b): יודעים היו ישראל בעבודה זרה שאין בה ממש, ולא עבדו עבודה זרה אלא להתיר להם עריות בפרהסיא. They knew idols were nothing; they worshipped them to permit forbidden relations openly.
   Rav Elchanan Wasserman on **לבבכם: ולא תתורו אחרי לבבכם ואחרי עיניכם = heresy; עיניכם = promiscuity** (Berachot). **Why in one verse? We stray after the heart *so that* we can stray after the eyes.**

3. **Tanach never tries to prove God.** "It's **a given** throughout Tanach and Talmud. **Only the Rishonim** began offering proofs."

Argument 1: the cosmological argument

The most common: **Rav Saadia**, **the Rambam (Moreh)**, **Rav Yosef Albo**, **Rabbeinu Bachya ibn Pakuda (*Chovot HaLevavot*)**.

Simply: the computer, the table: made by a technician, a carpenter; who made the carpenter? His parents; theirs... **A dependent thing can't be the final cause**, so trace back to **Hashem**.

The standard refutation (Kant): the argument assumes **everything needs a cause**, then concludes with **something uncaused**. "**Why posit God at the end? Posit an infinitely old universe.**" "**Fair.** But at least that's now **50/50**: **agnostic, not atheist**."

The Rambam's deeper version (Moreh)

Step	
1	Everything in the universe is **physical and finite**: bounded, however vast
2	**The physical and finite must have a cause** and **can't be infinitely old**
3	So we must posit something **non-physical and infinite**: the **מצוי ראשון**

What "infinite" really means:

"**33.333...**: each step is **finite**." **A blob that doubles every second** would, in an hour, fill the universe; in a thousand years be **billions of universes**. **Still, at any moment you could measure it.** "**Indefinitely extendable, not infinite.** Bigness isn't infinity."

Anything measurable is finite. Only **zero** has no edges, **and zero is negation**. **Infinity is like zero, but existent**: **no space, no time, no shape**.

So the universe, being physical, can be very, very old, but not infinitely. Once there was **no space, no time, nothing. We need something above space, time and boundaries**, which the physical depends on: **that's the infinite God. Not *huge*: beyond all boundaries.**

Against Aristotle. "**Until the 1960s**, many believed like Aristotle that the universe is infinitely old. **Now we know it had a beginning. The Rambam was proven right.**" He revered Aristotle, even implying **something like prophecy**, yet argued here. "*If I thought Aristotle were right philosophically, I'd reinterpret בראשית ברא אלהים. That's not why I disagree. I think he's philosophically wrong.*"

Robert's challenge: *matter is never destroyed, only changed into energy. Infinite forward in time. Then why not backward?*

"**The Rambam also writes there's no reason the world must end.** I hear that. **Let me think about it.** None of these are foolproof."

Argument 2: design (teleological)

The Rambam and *Chovot HaLevavot*: the order of the universe, the sun at **just the right distance**, can't be accident.

Rabbeinu Bachya: you find a page of **fresh ink**. *A dog knocked over the quill*: a **0.001%** chance. **Logic says someone wrote it.**

The Rambam (Yesodei HaTorah): love of Hashem comes from contemplating **how beautiful and precise** the world is.

Avraham (the Midrash): a burning palace: **מי בעל הבירה? Who owns this palace?** Hashem appeared and told him.

Objection: evil and suffering. "**That needs an explanation, a different discussion.** It doesn't negate **the design we clearly see** elsewhere."

Evolution: "**Absolutely acceptable**, provided you posit **a Creator behind the process**."

Other arguments

- **Tradition** (the **Kuzari**): the chain back to Sinai; the Torah couldn't have been falsified.
- **The ontological argument** (Christian; "I haven't seen it in the Rishonim"): **a dragon** combines things we know: a horse, birds' wings, fire. **But nothing in experience resembles God.** How could humans conceive Him if He didn't exist?
- **Fulfilled prophecy.** "**The State of Israel** is one of the strongest proofs. **A miracle in itself.**"

"You don't need to prove love"

Rav Soloveitchik, quoting Kierkegaard: a **bride and groom** in each other's arms **don't need to prove** their love. "**Some things you just feel.**"

"A philosopher argued **nothing exists except in your imagination**; the only certainty is **that you yourself think**. You can doubt even me. **But I know you're here. So too with Hashem.** We work through the arguments, **but the deepest *emunah* is when you feel His embrace.**"

"When I was younger I spent a lot of time on these questions; they **bothered me a lot**. **Some people have doubts, and that's acceptable.** But living with Torah and mitzvot, **many come to just feel Hashem's presence. That's the deepest *emunah*.**"

How He created

"**Nothing precludes a *frum* Jew believing Hashem created through a Big Bang, or through evolution, or both.** Principle 1 says **there's a Creator of the first matter**."

Rebbe Nachman (*Likutei Moharan* II:52), in substance: **it's fitting that there be objections to God's existence**, because He is **so exalted above our minds**. "I don't fully understand it, but: **never push people away. If they struggle, help them.**"

A coming debate. "In January I'll debate **a neighbour, a professor of science and avowed atheist**, publicly, with the community. **He'll know more science than me.** But some things you feel, and **rationally it's beyond reasonable doubt**: **where did first matter come from? Where did consciousness begin?**"

Part 3: Principle 2 Begins

היסוד השני: יחוד השם יתברך, כלומר שנאמין שזה שהוא סיבת הכל אחד. ואיננו כאחד הזוג, ולא כאחד המין, ולא כאיש אחד שהוא נחלק לאחדים רבים, ולא כגוף הפשוט האחד במנין שמקבל החלוק לאין תכלית. אבל השם יתברך אחד באחדות שאין כמותה אחדות. וזה היסוד השני, מורה עליו מה שנאמר: שמע ישראל ה׳ אלהינו ה׳ אחד.

Note: not simply "God is one," but **the Cause of everything is one**, and **not "one" in any ordinary sense**:

Not one as...	Because
One pair	A pair of socks splits into **two socks**
One species	"**The human race**" contains many
One person	A person has **many parts**
One simple body	Even it is **endlessly divisible**

אחד באחדות שאין כמותה אחדות: he writes it's **almost impossible to explain** one with a unity unlike any other unity. What that is, he doesn't say here; in the Mishneh Torah.

Yigdal: אחד ואין יחיד כיחודו, נעלם וגם אין סוף לאחדותו	**A precise encapsulation**: no unity like His, hidden, without end
Ani Ma'amin: שהבורא... הוא יחיד ואין יחידות כמוהו בשום פנים, והוא לבדו אלהינו, היה הוה ויהיה	Same, plus **the only God**

Summary

1. **Principle 1 has five elements:** a **Creator**; **perfect** (omnipotent, but **can't do the impossible**, no imperfection; contra Rebbe Nachman); **depending on nothing** (**Hashem doesn't need our prayers**); **sustaining everything continuously** (no deism: **the imagined universe**); **necessary** (*emet*).
2. **Arguments:** never 100% (free will); beware **unconscious bias** (Huxley; idolatry *to permit immorality*; **heart before eyes**). Tanach never tries.
3. **Cosmological** (Saadia, Rambam, Albo, Chovot HaLevavot), refined by the Rambam: **the finite can't be infinitely old**, so the **infinite** is beyond space and time. **Proven right against Aristotle.** (Robert: matter seems endless *forward*; "let me think.")
4. **Design** (ink on paper; **מי בעל הבירה**); evil is a separate question; **evolution is fine** with a Creator.
5. **Tradition, ontological, prophecy** (Israel).
6. **The deepest *emunah* is felt**, like love (Soloveitchik/Kierkegaard). **Never push away those who struggle** (Rebbe Nachman).
7. **Principle 2 begins: one with a unity like no other**: not a pair, species, person or body.

Coming Up

Next week, Principle 2 in full: monotheism vs polytheism, dualism and deism in the Rishonim, and **what the Rambam means by a unity beyond all unity**. *(Thursday: the chazarah shiur.)*

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